

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny 58/33 • Tomorrow: Rain, snow 40/33 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 4, 2025 • \$4

As wreckage rises, search for remains continues



JOHN MCDONNELL FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A crane lifts part of a catastrophically damaged American Airlines regional jet out of the Potomac River on Monday. Extracting the plane will allow rescue workers to more easily search for the remaining bodies of those who perished when Flight 5342 and a military Black Hawk helicopter collided Wednesday night. **Story, B1**

Trump preps order to dismantle Education Dept.

BY LAURA MECKLER,
DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL
AND HANNAH NATANSON

President Donald Trump is preparing an executive order aimed at eventually closing the Education Department and, in the short term, dismantling it from within, according to three people briefed on its contents.

The draft order acknowledges that only Congress can shut down the department and instead directs the agency to begin

Plans are set in motion as ‘DOGE’ agents probe sensitive internal data

to diminish itself, these people said, speaking on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly about internal issues.

That work is underway already. The new administration

has been trying to reduce the workforce by putting scores of employees on administrative leave and pressuring staff to voluntarily quit.

And roughly 20 people with Elon Musk’s “Department of Government Efficiency,” known as DOGE, have begun working inside the Education Department, looking to cut spending and staff, according to three people familiar with the situation and records obtained by The Washington Post.

At least some DOGE staffers have gained access to multiple sensitive internal systems, the people said, including a financial aid dataset that contains the personal information for millions of students enrolled in the federal student aid program.

The DOGE probe, which began last week, is a prelude to a more dramatic effort to make good on

SEE EDUCATION ON A24

Federal spending: Judge extends ban on OMB’s funding freeze. **B1**

Trump agrees to pause tariffs on Mexico, Canada

NATIONS VOW TO BOLSTER BORDER SECURITY

Leaders’ last-minute calls avert trade war for now

BY DAVID J. LYNCH
AND MARY BETH SHERIDAN

President Donald Trump agreed Monday to grant Mexico and Canada a 30-day reprieve on the U.S. tariffs that were scheduled to take effect Tuesday, after both countries pledged to intensify their efforts to prevent illicit drugs and migrants from crossing into the United States.

The president’s decision, which followed separate telephone conversations with the Mexican and Canadian leaders, averted — at least for now — an economic shock that was expected to push both U.S. neighbors into recession while slowing

growth and raising inflation in the United States.

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum was the first to secure a tariffs extension, when she promised to rush 10,000 national guard troops to the border to block the flow of fentanyl and other drugs into the United States. Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau needed two calls with Trump before securing a delay in return for implementing

SEE TARIFFS ON A10

Fentanyl: Trump frames levies on China as accountability for crisis. **A9**

South Africa: Trump threatens to cut aid over land expropriation. **A9**

Musk does ‘dirty work’ to enact Trump agenda

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF
AND JACQUELINE ALEMANY

After being almost inseparable between Election Day and Inauguration Day, President Donald Trump and billionaire donor Elon Musk are starting to divide and conquer.

Trump, who spent the weekend at his Florida club, left Friday amid a massive potential purge of federal prosecutors and FBI agents involved in cases against him and supporters who attacked the Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021. On Saturday morning he ordered airstrikes on an Islamic State leader in Somalia and posted

video of the explosions online. He golfed, then started a trade war with the United States’ neighbors and closest trading partners.

Musk, the richest man in the world — whose election spending to help Trump topped \$288 million — dove into his stated mission of cutting \$4 billion a day. His “Department of Government Efficiency” team took control of the Treasury Department’s payment system, federal personnel files, and the agency that handles government contracts, real estate and equipment. Officials who raised concerns about access to sensitive systems were put on

SEE MUSK ON A7

Work is halted at CFPB on acting head’s orders

Consumer watchdog agency’s staff told to stop crafting, enforcing rules

BY TONY ROMM

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau halted much of its work to investigate and penalize corporate wrongdoing Monday, after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent — tapped to lead the watchdog on an acting basis — ordered an agency-wide review to “promote consistency” with the new Trump administration.

Shortly after assuming the post,

Bessent and his aides ordered the bureau’s staff in an email to cease crafting regulations, enforcing rules, conducting probes or providing “public communications of any type,” according to a copy obtained by The Washington Post, which said he had instituted the ban “effective immediately.”

The missive appeared to herald a stark shift for the CFPB, a powerful agency formed in the wake of the 2008 banking crisis to protect consumers from unfair, deceptive or predatory financial practices. It came on the same day that President Donald Trump named

SEE CFPB ON A4

USAID restructuring: Rubio plans to review “duplicative” agency. **A4**



KENT NISHIMURA/REUTERS

A federal officer turns away a person trying to enter USAID’s D.C. offices. Like the CFPB, the agency is facing a stark reconfiguration.



OCTAVIO JONES FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Armando, 11, with his mother, was accused of making a “hit list” and threatening other students.

Jailed for jokes in the age of the gun

After Ga. shooting, police cracked down on students who made threats

BY JOHN WOODROW COX
AND HANNAH NATANSON
IN VOLUSIA COUNTY, FLA.

The dragnet first snagged a girl named Laurie, who was lying in bed amid her stuffed unicorns and Hello Kitty dolls when the ninth-grader had what she thought was a funny idea. She opened Instagram and, over a hot pink background, began to type: “Blowing the skl up tmr...” It was Sept. 10, six days after

another 14-year-old was accused of gunning down two students and a pair of teachers at Apalachee High in Georgia. At Laurie’s home in Florida, she posted the message and forgot about it until a few hours later, when a friend urged her to delete what she’d written.

It was too late, of course, because the internet is forever and because, unbeknownst to Laurie and hundreds of other kids, law enforcement’s tolerance for

threats of any kind, made anywhere, by anyone, was nearing zero.

The next day, the girl, 14, was placed in handcuffs that barely fit her wrists, charged with a felony and taken to a Volusia County detention center for three weeks. The day after that, another 14-year-old was charged for a comment on Instagram (“if yall crybabys don’t shut up ima shoot up your school”). The day

SEE THREATS ON A15

Prosecutor issues legal threat over ‘DOGE’

In unusual statement, U.S. attorney pledges to protect Musk’s initiative

BY SPENCER S. HSU
AND PATRICK MARLEY

Interim U.S. attorney Edward R. Martin Jr. alleged in a statement Monday that his office in D.C. had found evidence that people “committed acts that appear to violate the law in targeting” employees of Elon Musk’s “Department of Government Efficiency” — an unusual statement that came without any public criminal charges.

Hours after making public a letter he wrote to Musk saying the U.S. attorney’s office would “pursue any and all legal action against anyone who impedes your work or threatens your people,” Martin posted on X that his “initial review of the evidence” had found wrongdoing and hinted that he planned to take legal action.

“We are in contact with FBI and other law-enforcement partners to proceed rapidly. We also have our prosecutors preparing,” Martin said.

SEE MARTIN ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Invading the brain Microplastics are entering the organ in rising concentrations, with potentially harmful effects, a study found. **A6**

Border enforcement In an unprecedented move, federal authorities have deputized Texas National Guard troops to arrest and detain immigrants. **A19**

THE NATION

The vote of GOP Sen. Bill Cassidy, a doctor, could be pivotal for Robert F. Kennedy Jr. **A2**
Key Cabinet picks avoid stating explicitly that Donald Trump lost the 2020 election. **A3**

THE WORLD

A man wanted by Ukraine was killed in an explosion in Moscow. **A8**
Republicans, once critical of the top cyber-defense agency, now see it as a bulwark against China’s hackers. **A17**

THE ECONOMY

Many agricultural workers who labored during the wildfires in Southern California were not given masks, despite laws meant to require them. **A18**
Professors and worker advocates sued to block orders that target DEI programs. **A20**

THE REGION

The D.C. Council is set to expel Trayon White Sr. (D-Ward 8) before his trial on a federal bribery charge, a move some in the District say is an overreach. **B1**
Union Kitchen’s owner settled with grocery workers over claims of wage theft. **B1**

STYLE

Beyoncé finally roped in the Grammy for album of the year with “Cowboy Carter.” **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE

A scientist is harnessing the power of gene-editing technology as part of an effort to bring the dodo back from extinction. **E1**

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